



Gyeongbokgung Palace

Destroyed and rebuilt several times, a potent symbol of the pride and resilience of the Korean people



△ RISEN FROM THE ASHES

The reconstructed Heungnyemun Gate complex leads through to the two-story Geunjeongjeon (Throne Hall), one of the few buildings to survive the 20th-century destruction.

Also known as the Northern Palace, the Gyeongbokgung Palace is the largest of five palaces in Seoul that were home to the kings of Korea's ruling Joseon dynasty (1392–1910). Built in 1395, it was the main palace of the kings until it was destroyed during the Japanese invasion in the 1590s.

Surviving examples

In the 19th century, the regent, Heungseon Daewongun, rebuilt the palace, creating a vast complex of over 330 buildings covering 0.2 square miles (0.6 square km). This was largely destroyed during the Japanese occupation of Korea (1910–1945). However, several 19th-century buildings survived, providing beautiful examples of traditional Korean stone-and-wood architecture and decoration. They include the ornate two-story Geunjeongjeon (Imperial Throne Hall), the Gyeonghoeru (Royal Banqueting Hall), and Jagyeongjeon Hall (Quarters of the King's mother).

▷ SYMBOLIC COLORS

In traditional Korean building decoration (*Dancheong*), the paintwork protects the wood from the elements and the colors symbolize the compass points, the seasons, and both real and mythical creatures.

